‘A Date Which Will Live in Infamy’

President Franklin D. Roosevelt · Address to Joint Session of Congress · December 8, 1941

Source: Franklin D. Roosevelt, Address to Congress Requesting a Declaration of War (Dec. 8, 1941), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Less than 24 hours after the Japanese surprise attack on Pearl Harbor (December 7, 1941), FDR addressed a joint session of Congress. The original draft began ‘a date which will live in world history’; FDR himself penciled in ‘infamy.’ Within an hour of the speech, Congress voted overwhelmingly (388–1 in the House; 82–0 in the Senate) to declare war on Japan. Germany and Italy declared war on the U.S. three days later.

Connect: WWII gave African Americans and women wartime opportunities that fed into the postwar civil rights and women’s movements. Trace ONE line from 1942 to a 1960s development.

Key Passages

Opening

Yesterday, December 7, 1941—a date which will live in infamy—the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan. The United States was at peace with that Nation and, at the solicitation of Japan, was still in conversation with its Government and its Emperor looking toward the maintenance of peace in the Pacific.

On the scale of the attack

Yesterday the Japanese Government also launched an attack against Malaya. Last night Japanese forces attacked Hong Kong. Last night Japanese forces attacked Guam. Last night Japanese forces attacked the Philippine Islands. Last night the Japanese attacked Wake Island. And this morning the Japanese attacked Midway Island. Japan has, therefore, undertaken a surprise offensive extending throughout the Pacific area.

The request

No matter how long it may take us to overcome this premeditated invasion, the American people in their righteous might will win through to absolute victory. … I ask that the Congress declare that since the unprovoked and dastardly attack by Japan on Sunday, December 7, 1941, a state of war has existed between the United States and the Japanese Empire.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Japan's surprise attack on Pearl Harbor the day before (December 7, 1941) after years of rising tension over Japanese expansion in Asia.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, which he asked to declare war, and the American public listening on radio.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Franklin Roosevelt, who had already been aiding the Allies and needed to unite a nation that had been divided over entering the war.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — compare two theaters of war: Identify ONE major difference between U.S. operations in the Pacific theater and in the European theater.
2. Why did FDR specifically list each Japanese attack rather than summarize?
3. Identify ONE specific economic or technological development that gave the U.S. an advantage in WWII.

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> The day after Pearl Harbor, Roosevelt asked Congress to declare war on Japan, framing the surprise attack as an act of treachery that united the nation behind entry into World War II.

The address to Congress, December 8, 1941

Mr. Vice President, and Mr. Speaker, and Members of the Senate and House of Representatives: Yesterday, December 7, 1941—a date which will live in infamy—the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan. The United States was at peace with that Nation and, at the solicitation of Japan, was still in conversation with its Government and its Emperor looking toward the maintenance of peace in the Pacific. Indeed, one hour after Japanese air squadrons had commenced bombing in the American Island of Oahu, the Japanese Ambassador to the United States and his colleague delivered to our Secretary of State a formal reply to a recent American message. And while this reply stated that it seemed useless to continue the existing diplomatic negotiations, it contained no threat or hint of war or of armed attack. It will be recorded that the distance of Hawaii from Japan makes it obvious that the attack was deliberately planned many days or even weeks ago. During the intervening time the Japanese Government has deliberately sought to deceive the United States by false statements and expressions of hope for continued peace. The attack yesterday on the Hawaiian Islands has caused severe damage to American naval and military forces. I regret to tell you that very many American lives have been lost. In addition American ships have been reported torpedoed on the high seas between San Francisco and Honolulu. Yesterday the Japanese Government also launched an attack against Malaya. Last night Japanese forces attacked Hong Kong. Last night Japanese forces attacked Guam. Last night Japanese forces attacked the Philippine Islands. Last night the Japanese attacked Wake Island. And this morning the Japanese attacked Midway Island. Japan has, therefore, undertaken a surprise offensive extending throughout the Pacific area. The facts of yesterday and today speak for themselves. The people of the United States have already formed their opinions and well understand the implications to the very life and safety of our Nation. As Commander in Chief of the Army and Navy I have directed that all measures be taken for our defense. But always will our whole Nation remember the character of the onslaught against us. No matter how long it may take us to overcome this premeditated invasion, the American people in their righteous might will win through to absolute victory. I believe that I interpret the will of the Congress and of the people when I assert that we will not only defend ourselves to the uttermost but will make it very certain that this form of treachery shall never again endanger us. Hostilities exist. There is no blinking at the fact that our people, our territory, and our interests are in grave danger. With confidence in our armed forces — with the unbounding determination of our people — we will gain the inevitable triumph — so help us God. I ask that the Congress declare that since the unprovoked and dastardly attack by Japan on Sunday, December 7, 1941, a state of war has existed between the United States and the Japanese Empire.

Words to know

infamy — lasting shame and disgrace; being remembered for evil
solicitation — request; Japan itself asked to keep talking
premeditated — planned out in advance
treachery — betrayal; attacking while pretending to want peace
Hostilities — open acts of war
dastardly — cowardly and wicked